

ART, HISTORY OF



FROM THE EARLIEST TIMES, people all over the world have expressed their thoughts and feelings by making art. Over the centuries, styles in the visual arts (sculpture, painting, and drawing) have changed. These differences reflect the changing beliefs and traditions people held as their societies developed. Materials have changed as well, allowing artists to try new ways of reflecting the world around them.

Classical art

Western European art stems directly from the traditions of the ancient Mediterranean world, and especially the art of ancient Greece and Rome. In particular, sculpture from these civilizations is remarkably lifelike, or naturalistic, and concentrates on the human figure.

Fresco from Pompeii



Roman wall painting

Most ancient paintings have not survived. This one was preserved by volcanic ash at Pompeii. It shows figures from Roman mythology, and was painted on a wall to decorate the interior of a Roman house.

Hermes and Dionysus, 4th century BC



Hermes and Dionysus

This Greek marble statue shows the messenger god, Hermes, holding a baby Dionysus, the god of wine. The work displays a sure knowledge of human anatomy, such as the structure of bone and muscle. It also represents the human body as an ideal form, at its peak of physical beauty. It is believed to be by Praxiteles, the most famous ancient Greek sculptor.



Mineral, ground into pigment

Early paint making

The materials used to produce a painting affect the way it looks. Before oil paints arrived in the 15th century, artists worked straight onto wet plaster with tempera, a mixture of egg and paint pigment. Oil paints, which were more flexible and gave a more realistic finish, soon became the favourite medium.

Egg tempera

Egg (either the yolk or both yolk and white) provides a strong medium for colours, but is sticky and quick-drying, so difficult to apply.



Oil paint

As a medium, oil has the advantage of being slow to dry, allowing artists to make changes while they work.

Oil for binding paint pigment



Egg yolk

Value of colour

Certain colours, such as gold, have always been more expensive than others. Until the 17th century, dark blue was the most costly because it was made from lapis lazuli, a semi-precious stone.



Lapis lazuli

Scales weigh pigment



Early art

The earliest works of art usually seem to have had a religious or magical purpose: to represent a god, for example, or to bring a hunter luck as he stalked animals.



Sumerian sculpture

A rich artistic tradition grew up in ancient Sumer (now southern Iraq) during the 3rd millennium BC. This statue, which shows a Sumerian ruler, is carved from hard stone. It represents the strength and dignity of a good leader.

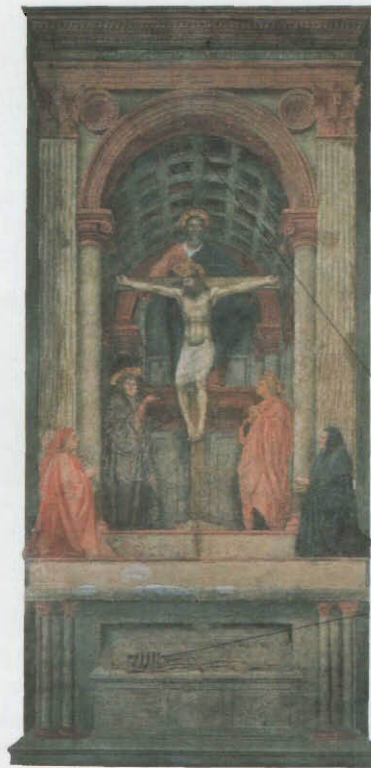


Caves at Lascaux

These extraordinary pictures of wild animals were painted in French caves more than 17,000 years ago. The outlines were painted by hand, and the vivid colours were filled in by spraying pigment through tubes of bone.

Renaissance

After the fall of the Roman Empire, Classical art was considered too pagan for the Christian civilizations which began to develop in Europe. By the 15th century, painters, sculptors, and architects began to revive a classical tradition in the arts, creating highly lifelike Christian works of art. This revival is called the Renaissance, from the French for "rebirth". It began in Italy and spread through Europe. Influential artists included Michelangelo (1475–1564).



Masaccio, *The Holy Trinity*, 1428

Painted vault gives sense of space.

Skeleton, a symbol of mortality



Jan Van Eyck, *The Arnolfini Marriage*, 1434